ranged from the Anushilan and Yogantar groups in Bengal to the Ghadar Party in Punjab. He did that at a meeting which extended over 8 and 9 September 1928. It was at the Ferozeshah Kotla Fort that he brought all these groups together under the banner of the Hindustan Republican Association (HRA). It remains significant that revolutionaries came to this meeting from as far afield as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Rajasthan and Punjab. What Bhagat Singh now did was both to add the word 'socialism' to turn it into the 'HSRA' and to propose that a central committee of seven members run it. At that meeting, Chandrashekhar Azad was elected the commander-in-chief of the HSRA. Not only was it agreed to boycott the Simon Commission, but a further 'action' was also agreed upon, namely, to throw a bomb at the train that carried its members. It was also agreed that bomb factories should be set up in Saharanpur, Agra and in Lahore.[1]

It is time therefore to openly acknowledge that in the build-up to Indian Independence, there were two rival traditions vying for recognition: one was the Gandhian tradition of 'non-violence', and the other was the revolutionary tradition of a 'violent struggle for freedom'. An alternative to Gandhian non-violence is once again being given attention because of the path that Indian democracy is currently eking out for itself. As retired Indian Supreme Court Justice Katju has recently lamented, 'The path of Gandhi and his associates like Nehru, Patel, etc. resulted in parliamentary democracy, which in India really means appeasing and appealing to caste and communal vote banks.' For him, '[c]asteism and communalism are feudal forces which must be destroyed if India is to progress, but parliamentary democracy further entrenches them'. It is in this way that 'the path of Gandhi and his associates continues to divide India on caste and communal lines, whereas if we had adopted the path of Bhagat Singh and Surya Sen we would have become united in our struggle against poverty, unemployment and other evils, and like China emerged as an industrialised and powerful nation, with our people enjoying decent lives'.[2] This, therefore, acknowledges the possibility of a rival tradition, and one adopted by neighbouring China, which has been vanquished but which would have made all the difference, had it been allowed to flourish.